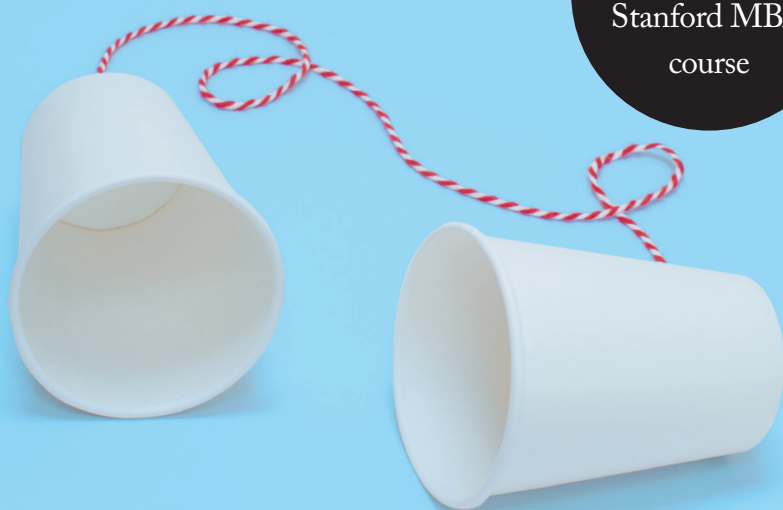


‘A practical and timely book I highly recommend’

Arianna Huffington, founder and CEO, Thrive Global

Connect

Based on the
transformational
Stanford MBA
course



**Building Exceptional
Relationships with Family,
Friends and Colleagues**

**David Bradford and
Carole Robin**

Praise for C O N N E C T

‘Carole Robin and David Bradford are masters at helping people bring IQ and EQ together to satisfy both and be successful. I recommend this book’

RAY DALIO, founder of Bridgewater Associates
and author of *Principles: Life and Work*

‘It’s never been clearer that meaningful relationships are critical to a fulfilling and healthy life. *Connect* is a practical and timely book I highly recommend that shows us that by learning to connect with ourselves, we can more easily connect with others and build thriving relationships’

ARIANNA HUFFINGTON, founder and CEO of Thrive Global

‘At LinkedIn, we made “Relationships Matter” one of our core values because the personal connections you make persist across jobs, companies and careers. *Connect* offers a compelling and highly accessible road map for building relationships that leads to professional success and personal fulfillment. I highly recommend this book’

REID HOFFMAN, co-founder of LinkedIn
and co-author of *Blitzscaling* and *The Alliance*

‘Learning to connect across differences and develop relationships in which we can actually see and hear others for who they are is becoming an imperative for nations and individuals alike. *Connect* is a carefully structured set of concepts and practices that readers can apply to everything from their marriages to their management challenges. It’s a treasure!’

ANNE-MARIE SLAUGHTER, CEO of New America

‘One of my goals, and the reason I founded MasterClass, is my fervent commitment to democratizing access to the world’s best. I am thrilled that the immensely valuable lessons in *Connect* are now available to millions of people. I encourage anyone who cares about developing stronger and more meaningful relationships anywhere in their life to read this book’

DAVID ROGIER, founder and CEO of MasterClass

‘I owe most of what I have accomplished in both my career and my personal life to the lessons I learned in the course on which *Connect* is based. I can’t wait to give a copy of *Connect* to my teammates, my family and my friends’

DARA TRESEDER, CMO of Peloton and board director of PG&E

‘Decades in business have shown me that building high-trust relationships is one of the most important keys to success, whether in negotiations or on the basketball court. With practical insights into relationship building in both personal and professional environments, *Connect* is the best book in its class’

IRV GROUSBECK, entrepreneur, co-owner of the Boston Celtics
and professor at the Stanford Graduate School of Business

‘Carole and David’s classes have been an invaluable resource – what a gift to have their insights and lessons in a book. I would recommend it to anyone who wants to feel happier and more fulfilled, and to anyone who wants a better, smarter future for our world’

DR JENNIFER AAKER, co-author of *Humour, Seriously*
and *The Dragonfly Effect*

CONNECT

CONNECT

BUILDING EXCEPTIONAL
RELATIONSHIPS WITH FAMILY,
FRIENDS AND COLLEAGUES

DAVID BRADFORD, PHD

CAROLE ROBIN, PHD



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*To Eva and Andy—
our heroic spouses who love and accept us
for who we are and whose patience and support
sustained us throughout this journey*

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CONNECT

1

SEEKING EXCEPTIONAL

This book is about a special type of relationship we call *exceptional*. You may have one or two exceptional relationships already—maybe even more. In these relationships, you feel seen, known, and appreciated for who you really are, not an edited version of yourself. Your hundreds of Instagram friends might know what you ordered for dinner at that fancy restaurant last week, but the person you have an exceptional relationship with knows that you’ve actually been struggling with food issues for years, or that this was the dinner when you and your partner talked about starting a family, or that the impetus for the evening was to discuss the pros and cons of leaving your job. Those subjects are off-limits to the friend you haven’t seen since high school who follows your feed. They rarely come up with the person you carpool with. They are not germane to the aunt you check in on every so often. But someone you’re in an exceptional relationship with knows what’s really going on for you because that someone really knows *you*.

Relationships exist on a continuum. At one end you experience contact without real connection, while at the other end you feel known, supported, affirmed, and fully accepted. In the middle of the continuum, you feel attached to people in your life, but with

many, you want closer connection. The question is, *How?* How do you move along this continuum? We have dedicated our lives to answering this question for thousands of students and clients, and now, for you.

Exceptional relationships *can* be developed. They have six hallmarks:

1. You can be more fully yourself, and so can the other person.
2. Both of you are willing to be vulnerable.
3. You trust that self-disclosures will not be used against you.
4. You can be honest with each other.
5. You deal with conflict productively.
6. Both of you are committed to each other's growth and development.

Let's unpack these a bit.

THE FIRST THREE center around self-disclosure. Why are we still talking about this, when many would say we've become a culture of oversharers? Because there is a difference between a presented image and sharing who you really are. Oscar Wilde, among others, wryly commented, "Be yourself, everybody else is taken." Too often, we edit what we disclose out of fear of being poorly judged.

Social media has created a world where we're pressured to spin everything into a positive. Your Facebook posts might show you smiling in front of the Eiffel Tower, but in reality, the trip was a disaster. Silicon Valley CEOs we know talk about the incessant need to describe everything in terms of how much they are "crushing it,"

but fatigue, fear, and burnout are very real in the Valley. It's exhausting to keep up these false fronts. Editing and spinning who you are not only costs you your ability to be authentic but leads others to create their own spin. We're not suggesting you have to reveal everything to one single person. But you do have to share the parts of yourself that are important to that specific relationship. And what you share needs to be the real, wholly authentic you, not one obscured by a smiling vacation picture or cheery holiday greetings.

The last three hallmarks have to do with feedback and conflict. Challenging someone can actually be a powerful way of supporting them, and yet few people feel confident they can do it well. Someone with whom you have an exceptional relationship calls you on behaviors that really bother them, and when they do, you know it's a chance for learning, not something against which you have to put up your guard. They know that in helping you understand the impact of your behavior, they are showing commitment to your relationship *and* helping you grow.

Fights happen, even in the best of relationships (as you'll see, the two of us are proof of that!). But a fear of conflict can lead you to bury irritants that, if raised and successfully dealt with, could actually deepen the relationship. Conflicts left unspoken can still cause harm. In an exceptional relationship, it's easier to raise and resolve issues so that they don't lurk and result in long-term damage. You see such challenges as opportunities to learn, which decreases the chance that these same difficulties will appear again.

WE HAVE SPENT our careers showing people what it takes to build and maintain strong, functional, and robust relationships in both personal and professional settings. We invite you to join the thousands of students and clients who have learned that, and more, from us. Our passion comes from results we've observed in our coaching, teaching, and consulting careers. We don't just study and teach the concepts in this book—we *live* them. Sometimes imperfectly;

David's wife of over fifty-five years has told him, "You teach this stuff—why aren't you doing it!" Carole's husband, Andy, has expressed similar sentiments to her. But we have always sought to live what we teach, and it has shaped our lives for the better.

Even so, we almost lost our exceptional relationship with each other. There was something that David did (or, more accurately, didn't do) that caused Carole to get to the point where she wanted to write him off and have nothing more to do with him. We'll go into the details in chapter 17, but the critical point is that even though we were at the brink of a total collapse of our relationship, we were able to come back and repair it. This allowed us to write this book together and, in the process, to develop an even more exceptional relationship. We are living proof that mistakes and misunderstandings happen, and repair and recovery are possible.

The two of us are teachers but will be the first to tell you that some lessons have to be experienced; that's why the focus of this book is on application. We worked in the business school of one of the world's most prestigious universities, but what we have to say has even more relevance outside the business sphere. And while the course we devoted decades of our lives to, *Interpersonal Dynamics*, is affectionately called "Touchy-Feely," there's nothing squishy about it. Soft skills require a lot of hard work.

The conceptual material in this book is based on social science research, especially interpersonal psychology, as well as decades of our own experience. David came to Stanford University's Graduate School of Business over fifty years ago to develop the *Interpersonal Dynamics* course and today is known as the "Father of Touchy-Feely." Carole joined twenty years ago, became known as the "Queen of Touchy-Feely," and helped expand the program, doubling its size.

Touchy-Feely remains, far and away, the most famous and popular course offered in the MBA program. Over 85 percent of students enroll, and they often have to place it high on their class ranking to

get in. Students frequently report the experience as “transformational,” and alumni regularly say that it was the most impactful course they took and one that they continue to use in their personal and professional lives. Lifelong friendships and even marriages have been forged among the students. It’s been written about in bestselling books like *Creative Confidence* by David Kelley, featured on the *Today* show, written about in *The New York Times*, and featured in *The Wall Street Journal*—all of which noted the importance of these skills in today’s organizational life.

As students quickly learn, just because the class is affectionately known as “Touchy-Feely” that does not mean it is easy. When they sign up for the course, they are placed in a twelve-person group known as a T-group, which meets for about sixty hours over the ten-week term. The “T” in T-group stands for “training,” not “therapy,” and its purpose is to provide a learning laboratory in which students can practice class concepts—such as the importance of self-disclosure, how to give and receive feedback, how to connect across differences, and how to influence one another—by interacting with one another and learning from the reactions of their peers. We firmly believe that the best way to learn to be more interpersonally effective is to engage with others in real situations and in real time rather than through lectures, readings, case studies, or, yes, even a book. While *Connect* covers everything that we teach during class, you will need to use the relationships in your life as your laboratory to get the maximum benefit. Throughout the book, we provide specific suggestions to show you how.

For students who are used to crunching numbers and muddling through problem sets, it can be initially jarring to sit in a group exploring who feels more connected to whom and why. But over the years, countless students who didn’t initially grasp what all the hype was about have left the class as true believers. (And no, it’s not a cult!) The class’s impact doesn’t come from brilliant comments from the faculty, as good as we might be. Our function is simply to

build conditions in which students learn how the way they behave impacts others—and what that might mean to their success as future leaders.

Experts have come to recognize that interpersonal/soft skills are fundamental to professional success. A central belief we hold is that people do business with people, not just with ideas, machines, strategies, or even money. Touchy-Feely provides the best opportunity to develop the soft skills that have become crucial to leadership success, such as connecting, building trust, and gaining influence. But students gain something even more profound, best captured by what one student said years ago: “I knew if I went to any top business school, I would learn how to be a better manager and leader. But I also believed if I came to Stanford, because of this class in particular, I would become a better human being—and that would in turn make me much more than a good leader.”

Whether at reunions or in all the emails we have received over the years, we hear, “This course saved my career/marriage ten years later.” “I use what I learned in Touchy-Feely at work almost every day.” “I know I am a better parent, spouse, and son/daughter, not to mention work colleague, as a result of this course.” A recent participant from an executive program said, “Surprisingly, this program didn’t explicitly focus on improving my leadership. It mostly taught me how to be a better person . . . and as a side effect, I’m a more effective leader, with improved self-awareness, compassion, vulnerability, and communication.”

Mastering these soft skills takes hard work, but they can be learned by anyone. That’s why it’s not just MBA students who benefit from the principles of Touchy-Feely, nor is it just a California woo-woo phenomenon. Similar groups with much more diverse participants have been conducted around the world—in Europe, Africa, the Middle East, Asia, and Latin America—with similar outcomes.

Beyond our academic experience, we have both been consultants

and executive coaches in hundreds of for-profit and nonprofit organizations in many countries, in multiple industries, and for companies ranging in size from Fortune 100s to startups. We jointly developed a very successful one-week executive version of the course for Stanford that senior managers from around the world attend. Carole now applies the same principles and process to developing Silicon Valley CEO/founders and investors.

One of the most striking observations we've had over the years is that deep, fulfilling, personal connections can happen with a wider range of people than we normally think possible. We can develop an exceptional relationship with someone whom we seem, outwardly, to have little in common with. We've seen it happen, again and again, in both personal and professional settings. What it takes are the skills to move beyond surface conversations. These don't necessarily require a lot of time, but they do require a commitment to truly learn about ourselves and about the other.

You won't develop them with everybody. That isn't possible, because these deep connections require a great deal of effort. What's more, it's not necessary. You probably have a range of people in your life, like tennis partners, people you go to movies and concerts with, or those you have over for dinner occasionally. You may have colleagues who offer great professional collaboration but who are not your closest friends. These relationships provide partnership, social interaction, intellectual stimulation, professional validation, and fun. They're less intense, and that's perfectly fine. What's more, you need them. Not every dessert can be chocolate soufflé, and not every interaction has to be with someone who knows you deeply.

Still, let's say you have some relationships in your life that you know could be stronger. You're not sure they'll ever reach "exceptional," but you know there's room for growth. Perhaps you'd like to learn how to go from casual to a bit more personal, from detached to somewhat more connected, from dysfunctional to functional, or from competitive to collaborative. Or perhaps you already

have some relationships that feel special and deep but that you sense could be even richer. The concepts in this book can help you move forward anywhere along the continuum.

We aren't promising you the "five easy steps to deep connections" because such steps don't exist. One size does not fit all. What works for you might not work for someone else, and something that helps grow one relationship might fall flat in another. Exceptional is also not an end state, because relationships can always grow deeper. Instead, think of exceptional relationships as living, breathing organisms that are always changing, always in need of tending, and always, *always* capable of taking your breath away.

We're straightforward about the effort required to build more meaningful relationships and just as straightforward about the benefits. We have seen its unequivocally profound impact on friendships, marriages, family systems, and work colleagues. We know that using what we teach results in stronger, happier, deeper relationships with less unnecessary conflict. When you have a sense of safety and honesty with another person, the opportunities for growth are unlimited. When your interactions with another person are at their most authentic, there is a paradigm shift. And in the end, an exceptional relationship is about more than a collection of skills and competencies; it's fundamentally about a different way of being. And therein lies something that feels magical.

2

A WORLD-CLASS COURSE, ONE CHAPTER AT A TIME

We know what Interpersonal Dynamics has delivered to generations of students. We've turned to the skills we teach time and time again when helping others deal with relationship challenges and when dealing with our own. Our students have urged us repeatedly to put the class material in book form so that they can refer back to it or share it with their friends, spouse, or business partners. Beyond that, we have a personal dream of bringing the benefits of this course to many thousands of people beyond Stanford and have long pondered the question of how to make these lessons available more widely.

There are challenges. The course this book is based on relies on close, experiential learning with a small group of students. Each student is committed to being in the same face-to-face group for ten weeks, so even if the going gets tough, there's no quitting. Conflicts work out in the groups as people get to see more nuanced sides of one another. Second, students get assistance from others in the group. If an interaction between two people doesn't go well, others step in and say, "Hey. What's going on here?" or "I'm feeling protective of Gabriel and want to make sure he's doing okay." And third, the class has cultural norms that support learning, including confidentiality and the idea that the only mistake is refusing to learn

from our mistakes. The latter reframes problems as learning opportunities.

These three factors certainly don't exist in a book. Yes, we can provide the same concepts, stories, and material covered in our lectures and readings, but we can't provide a group of eleven other peers to support your learning and keep you engaged. And we can't influence the cultural norms of your particular relationships. We like to think of ourselves as a pretty capable duo, but even so, we have our limits. There's also the challenge of helping you convert a conceptual understanding into actual behavior. After all, it's possible to *know* what to do without being able to actually do it. With experiential learning, you try something first and *then* learn about it.

So for this to work, first and foremost, we need your active involvement. In our classes, we say that those who sit back and observe will gain the least, while those who roll up their sleeves and really engage with one another will learn the most. In this book, we have created five scenarios that run throughout, each featuring two people at an inflection point in their relationship. The pairs we feature cover a wide gamut—from a daughter trying to change a decades-old way of relating with her father, to a married couple weighing their shared responsibilities against their individual needs, to work colleagues whose relationship is deepened and tested over time. All cases are an amalgamation of real relationships we have had or seen, and we ask that rather than reading the book passively, you work to imagine yourself in each situation.

In reading of their travails and putting yourself in their places, reflect on how you would feel and act. What does that say about what you do well and how you might limit yourself? Are there some competencies you need to develop? Then, when we describe ways that these situations could be handled, assess how easy that would be for you and what would be challenging. Explore what insights you can gain about yourself from your reactions. Taking an active stance will help you personalize the material.

Second, put what you're learning into practice. Each chapter

ends with self-reflection questions and suggestions for ways to apply your learning. Take the time you need between chapters to use these lessons, just as our students do between classes. Putting this material to work is not simple. You'll notice that in lieu of solid answers, we often give you options, because the specific solutions depend on you—on the sort of outcome you want, on your abilities, and on the risks you're willing to take.

Since relationships are co-determined, the right course of action also depends on the other person: What do they want? What can they handle? What's the context for the relationship? Instead of being constraining, this kind of flexibility is liberating. Though there's no guarantee you'll always succeed in getting the connections you want, you can learn from trying. In fact, if we had our druthers, you would read a single chapter, apply its lessons to your life, and then read the chapter again.

Third, fine-tune two crucial personal “antennae.” One of these needs to look outward, and the other needs to focus inward. If you only have the latter, you can't understand the other person, and if only the former, you lose yourself. In listening to both, you are more likely to act in ways that best fit the situation and your collective needs. Keeping those antennae highly tuned will help you see every interaction with another person as an opportunity to learn. A friend of ours has suggested the Stanford course should actually be called Interpersonal Mindfulness, because in order to engage with another in the ways we describe throughout the book, you have to become acutely aware of what's going on for you as well as for the other.

No, we're not grading you. But stick with it anyway.

The Arc of Relationships—and of This Book

All relationships vary, but most develop in a similar pattern. They often start with a common interest, like music or hiking. At other times, people might have complementary interests—one likes to

make plans and initiate activities, while the other finds it a chore. In this process, the two must learn how to relate to and influence each other. To what extent can the second person say no to plans the first suggests? To what extent can the first state when they are feeling used and push some of the scheduling responsibility onto the second?

This might be as far as you go with some people, and that's perfectly fine. For example, let's say you and a buddy both like basketball and have built an easy friendship, and that's enough of a bond for an enjoyable game every other weekend. Usually you talk about movies and current events (with certain contentious topics avoided), and that's satisfying to you both. In this relationship, neither of you feels the need to discuss your deepest worries or biggest dreams. As we said in chapter 1, not every friendship needs to be the equivalent of chocolate soufflé.

However, there are relationships that you want to take deeper. You move past these initial stages of getting to know each other and begin to communicate more openly and personally. As you do, mutual knowledge and understanding grow and you find more areas in which to connect. As trust builds, you're each increasingly willing to take risks about what you disclose, becoming even more vulnerable. The cycle continues and is reinforced, and the relationship develops. This deeper relationship allows you to discuss issues like difficulties at work or conflicts with your teenager that you wouldn't raise with a more casual friend.

As you become more important to each other, the relationship also becomes increasingly complex. Obligations and expectations build, as do potential points of contention. How will you deal with inevitable annoyances? If you can face and resolve them well, the relationship becomes even stronger. That in turn encourages each of you to surface what you want from the other and what's getting in the way. Openness and honesty grow. As the healthy relationship develops, you avoid power imbalances, so that you each get roughly the same amount of satisfaction.

As you negotiate your evolving relationship, you each learn how to influence the other. You build interdependence that makes it easy to ask for help when you need it and to turn it down when it's not useful. Challenges and conflict don't go away, but you know how to deal with them. When a relationship reaches this stage, each person can be of great support to the other. You can discuss issues openly, give and receive feedback, and grow as a result.

However, if the relationship is to progress even further, you have to significantly increase your level of disclosure and risk-taking. There is even greater risk since you both now have skin in the game. Sometimes the relationship deepens and reaches exceptional almost seamlessly, through years of joyful shared experiences, layered disclosures, and ever-increasing trust. But in most cases, one or more critical issues transform it. Let's suppose a major conflict emerges with the potential to tear the fabric of the relationship. You might decide it's better to let sleeping dogs lie and avoid the issue altogether. The relationship survives but plateaus. Facing the issue tests the relationship and might end it. But fully resolving the conflict strengthens the connection—you are moving toward exceptional territory.

Deep relationships take time—there is no instant intimacy. You can influence the speed and direction of a relationship's trajectory—and we'll show you some ways to do just that. But it takes two to tango, and so what develops in a relationship will also depend on the other person, including their willingness and ability to take these steps toward growth. You may be able to influence that, but you can't control it. The arc of development also isn't necessarily linear. A relationship may stay where it is for a while or even regress and then start growing again.

This book is structured to follow the rough arc of deepening relationships and is divided into two parts. In part I, we examine the six hallmarks of exceptional relationships described in the first chapter. These concepts are key to *all* functional, robust relationships, whether they end up becoming exceptional or not. We talk about

how to be more fully yourself and how to help others do the same. We cover the question of balance in a relationship and mutual influence. We examine how to deal with minor annoyances and more significant disagreements, and we ask what gets in the way of offering and hearing feedback. We explore the knotty question of whether people can change, and we look at the role curiosity plays in resolving conflicts.

In part II, we look at how relationships transition from very good to exceptional. What does it take to successfully resolve a major conflict and, in the process, deepen the connection? How do you set boundaries while still remaining close? We also look at the issue of entanglement, which can happen when personal issues for one person trigger pain for another. While not all relationships need to be tested to become exceptional, we've found that it's often in the testing stage that bonds become deeper and individuals become more skilled at forging and maintaining them.

When a relationship doesn't reach exceptional status, that doesn't mean you've failed, and it doesn't mean the relationship will never be exceptional. How to handle this tricky territory is the subject of chapter 16. And finally, the last chapter of the book discusses how our own relationship faced a crisis that almost ended it and how we pulled all of the learning in this book together to not only salvage what we had but deepen it. It was scary, and it is humbling to admit that even we who teach this stuff could so thoroughly screw up.

A Learning Mindset

Reportedly, as the French Impressionist painter Auguste Renoir lay dying at seventy-eight, his last words were, "I think I'm beginning to learn something about it." What a wonderful, open, exploratory mind. We have our own, saltier take on the same idea. Whenever we face challenges, we think, "Well, that's an AFOG"—which is short for "another f**king opportunity for growth."

We cannot stress enough how important such a learning mind-

set is, whether you go with Renoir's words or with ours. You can't significantly develop a relationship (and certainly can't reach exceptional) unless you're open to learning. This mindset isn't limited to new skills and competencies but also applies to a willingness to look within. In the 1970s there was a cartoon character, Pogo, who said, "We have met the enemy and he is us." It's easy to blame another when things go wrong, but it's necessary to also be willing to reflect on whether part of the enemy "is us."

A learning mindset has several characteristics. One is a willingness to let go of the idea that your way of doing things is always best. Another is being game to try new things and take the risk of making mistakes. And a third is seeing mistakes as learning opportunities rather than something to be embarrassed about and hide. Curiosity is key. Thinking, *I wonder why this isn't working*, is much more productive than blaming another person when something goes awry.

Having an open mind for continuous learning is a wonderful way to live. It means you're open to your own development, which includes acquiring the skills and competencies this book describes, reflecting on assumptions you hold that might limit you, and reconsidering behaviors that aren't serving you well. As Alan Alda said, "Your assumptions are your windows on the world. Scrub them off, every once in a while, or the light won't come in." Some changes might be relatively easy to make, and some might be very challenging, but it's all part of the magic of relationships.

When the going gets tough, there's a temptation to say, "I can't. That's not me." True, that may not be you *now*, but can it *never* be you? Perhaps it's not you *yet*, as described by psychologist Carol Dweck's work on growth mindsets. None of the skills and competencies we suggest are so esoteric that they can't be acquired. We say that with certainty because we have seen so many participants in the Interpersonal Dynamics course make the "I can't" disclaimer, only to learn the competencies by the end of the term. In every case, their mindset had to first shift from "I can't" to "I see I have a choice, even though it's hard." And while it is legitimate for differ-

ent people to make different choices, we must all acknowledge we've made a choice.

This is hard work, no doubt. But it's worth it. Good luck, and may you make many rich learning mistakes.

Introduction to Deepen Your Learning

To make the material in this book personally relevant, your first task is to select four or five relationships—with family, friends, or work colleagues—that you would like to significantly deepen. At the end of each chapter you will find a recurring “Self-Reflection” section in which we ask you to consider how the chapter content relates to those relationships. Regardless of what category of relationship you choose, keep in mind that the lessons learned in each chapter apply across all of them. In the recurring “Application” sections, we suggest ways to apply the material toward making those relationships stronger.

We encourage you to share your goals with the people you have chosen so that they have some context and understand why you will be asking them for help. You may want to stress that you see this as an opportunity to make the relationship you already value even stronger rather than only a learning opportunity for *you*. Hopefully, they will join you in your learning journey.

The third recurring section, “Making Sense,” asks you to reflect on what you learned from “doing.” Experiences have the most value when you try to make sense out of them. We'll ask you, as we ask our students, What was it like *applying* the concepts to a key relationship? What did you learn about yourself and about building stronger connections?

SELF-REFLECTION

The first chapter listed the following six characteristics of an exceptional relationship:

1. You can be more fully yourself, and so can the other person.
2. Both of you are willing to be vulnerable.
3. You trust that self-disclosures will not be used against you.
4. You can be honest with each other.
5. You deal with conflict productively.
6. Both of you are committed to each other's growth and development.

Take each of the key relationships that you have selected. For each one:

- Which one(s) of these six characteristics is strongest?
- Which one(s) of these six would you most want to improve on?
- What is it about what *you* (not the other person) do—or don't do—that contributes to the limitations you identified?

APPLICATION

Take one of the people you selected and initiate a conversation about what you would like from the relationship. Share your assessment from the self-reflection exercise above (including what you think you do and don't do), and find out whether they assess you, themselves, and the situation the same way.

MAKING SENSE

How did it go? What did you learn about yourself and about how you raise issues? How receptive were you to the other person's comments?

In this chapter, we covered some of the ways we block our learning. Did any of those limitations come up for you? What did you learn about the *process* of building stronger relationships?

NOTE: You might want to consider keeping a journal of what you learn from the “Deepen Your Learning” activities throughout the book. You will be returning to these relationships in subsequent chapters, and it will be interesting to see how they develop. Our students are required to keep a journal throughout the course, and while many of them hate it at the time, most thank us afterward!

PART I

GETTING TO THE
MEADOW